

FIELD OF VISION | SHARDA UGRA

Hockey Homecoming



It's a lovely sentimental tag-line: hockey comes home. Had the organisation of the Hero Honda World Cup sorted itself out between the International Hockey Federation, Hockey India, the Sports Authority of India, the Commonwealth Games Organising Committee, the Indian Olympic Association, Delhi Police and event organisers (or were Pogo channel and the Prime Minister's Office also involved?) maybe home would have had open arms.

Or at least good crowds. Rather than an 85 per cent capacity at the 16,000-seater Major Dhyan Chand National Stadium when the Indians took to the field and acres of vacant space on other days as players' families struggled to get tickets and the IOA handed out dozens in its possession as largesse to the media.

Yet, in the backdrop of an organisational ego-clash and under a landscape of circulating helicopters and moons made of Dutch cheese, hockey reiterated its sense of belonging in this country. Even though the sport is still treated like an old love letter left in a bottom drawer. Then suddenly India looks at it again, at *it*, the sport, not its politics or bitter battles or controversies. When India sees hockey, its attention and affection is seized and it falls in love yet again. It explains the reaction of the crowd when India plays at the World Cup. The peripherals don't matter; all they want is to be enraptured by magic.

To see a player break down the flank like a bolt of lightning and sizzle past defenders is to have heart rates go from 80 to 150 in a second. To see a midfielder's pass cut across the width of the field is to witness a single stroke become a wrecking ball on an adversary's architecture. To see defenders pull off sliding tackles in a jungle of sticks is to appreciate athletic courage in unheralded form. To see goalkeepers change directions to bat at a drag flick coming at 130 kmph is to realise what ballet dancers could do in a gridiron uniform.

We don't see more of this live and at home because India doesn't have a planned calendar. Poor results have led to bad rankings and expulsion from the major events where points can be earned. The World Cup is the best we will get to see what the team is made of today.

Beating Pakistan proved India could adapt to the modern game. Defeat to Australia was evidence that their hearts were in for a fight even though they still need to catch up with the best.

The difference in the pace at which India plays today, coach Jose Brasa believes, has to do with the fact that the Aussies are 25 years ahead in scientific training. Remember, that Indian captain Rajpal Singh is the fastest man on the ball in the Indian team and covers 30 m with the ball in about 4.11 seconds. Yet, hockey itself will never remain still. India must move quickly and the faster it goes, the quicker it will take a billion along.

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SAURABH SINGH/www.indiatodayimages.com

SIGNPOSTS

DIED: Nanaji Deshmukh, one of the founders of the Bharatiya Jan Sangh, the precursor of the Bharatiya Janata Party. A former member of



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both Houses of Parliament, he campaigned against the Emergency in 1975. He was also a leader of the Jaya Prakash Narayan Movement in Bihar in 1974. He founded the primary school chain Saraswati Sishu Mandir in 1950 and the country's first rural university in Madhya Pradesh in 1991. He was 93.

DIED: Senior Advocate **P.N. Lekhi**, 85, one of the government-appointed defence counsels in the Indira Gandhi assassination case who represented Satwant Singh, one of the accused.

CHOSEN: Social worker **Ela Bhatt**, 76, for Japan's Niwano Peace Prize for her contribution to the uplift of poor women in India. A former Rajya Sabha member, she founded the SEWA cooperative bank, which caters to 30 lakh women.